

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 37 OF 155

Citadel Chess

10×10 + 4 citadel squares

BOARD

2

PLAYERS

CITADEL CHESS

Citadel Chess (Shatranj al-Husun, “Chess of the Fortresses”) is a historical Shatranj variant described by Gollon (based on Murray and Pritchard). It is played on a 10×10 board augmented with four corner citadel squares. A King that reaches the opponent’s citadel and cannot be captured on the very next move secures a draw.

THE BOARD

The main playing area is a 10×10 grid (files b–k, ranks 2–11). Four additional citadel squares are positioned diagonally off each corner of the main grid:

- ♦ **a1** and **l1** — White’s citadels (adjacent to White’s back rank)
- ♦ **a12** and **l12** — Black’s citadels (adjacent to Black’s back rank)

Ranks 1 and 12 contain only the citadel squares (a1, l1, a12, l12); squares b1–k1 and b12–k12 do not exist. Files a and l have no squares other than the citadels. Total board size: 104 squares.

STARTING POSITION

White back rank (rank 2): Rook b2 · Knight c2 · War Machine d2 · Elephant e2 · King f2 · General g2 · War Machine h2 · Elephant i2 · Knight j2 · Rook k2

White pawns (rank 3): b3–k3 (10 pawns)

Black back rank (rank 11): Rook b11 · Knight c11 · War Machine d11 · Elephant e11 · King f11 · General g11 · War Machine h11 · Elephant i11 · Knight j11 · Rook k11

Black pawns (rank 10): b10–k10 (10 pawns)

Source note: The chessvariants.com source lists “Elephant c2, i2” but c2 is also given as the Knight square. By symmetry (Rook–Knight–War Machine–Elephant–King–General–War Machine–Elephant–Knight–Rook), the Elephants occupy e2 and i2.

PIECES

PIECE	MOVEMENT
King (Shah)	One square in any direction
General (Firzan)	One square diagonally
Elephant (Fil)	Leaps exactly 2 squares diagonally; can jump the intervening square
Knight (Faras)	L-shaped leap (as in standard chess)
Rook (Rukh)	Slides any distance orthogonally
Pawn	One square forward; captures one square diagonally; no double first step; promotes to General on reaching the last rank
War Machine (Dabbabah)	Slides any distance diagonally (as a modern Bishop)

CITADEL RULES

- ♦ A King may move into a citadel square on the **opponent's side** of the board (a12 or l12 for White; a1 or l1 for Black).
- ♦ If the King enters the opponent's citadel and **cannot be captured on the very next move**, the game is a **draw**.
- ♦ A player's own citadels (on their own side) grant no special benefit.

SPECIAL RULES

- ♦ **Stalemate** is a **win** for the stalemating player.
- ♦ **No bare King rule** — the game continues normally when a player has only the King.
- ♦ **No castling, no en passant.**
- ♦ **Promotion:** Pawns promote to Generals upon reaching the last rank.

ATTRIBUTION

Citadel Chess documented at chessvariants.com/historic.dir/citadel.html (Hans Bodlaender, from Gollon/Murray/Pritchard).